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By Nicole Villemaire, as told to Kiersten Hallquist, Think College Vermont at University of Vermont

My name is Nicole and I recently received my nine-credit Certificate of Professional Studies at the University of Vermont. When I think back to where I was a few years ago, it makes me proud to know that I have been a college student.

Three years after leaving high school, I knew I wanted to go to college. I wanted to interact with all types of people—including people without disabilities—and continue to grow. I wanted to take real college classes—classes that are not just for people with disabilities. I wanted mentors my age, instead of just program staff. I also wanted a support program that had a flexible schedule, so I could continue to work and participate in my other activities. Going to school for the first time after three years was intimidating, but at the same time I was excited to start a new stage in my life.

I chose to attend Think College Vermont (TCVT), a postsecondary education program at the University of Vermont (UVM), because it provided the kind of support and schedule structure I wanted. I was especially interested in receiving support from peers who were students without disabilities and not agency staff (TCVT has college mentors who are full-time UVM students). In this program, I was able to attend classes at UVM and receive support from my college peers.

One of my reasons for continuing my learning was that I would like to be a professional self-advocate one day. When I started at UVM, I took Written Expression during my first semester to make my writing better, and I took Foundations in Communication to improve my public speaking skills during my second semester. Then I had an internship-for-credit at Green Mountain Self-Advocates doing office work and working at different disability awareness events.



Nicole Villemaire, attending a University of Vermont picnic with friends

My professors gave me a lot of homework, due dates, and meetings, and I was expected to listen and understand the information the professors gave out; these are all important skills for any well-paying job in my future. I also watched my fellow students without disabilities keep up with the course and was motivated to move at a faster pace. I learned a lot over the three semesters attending these classes and being on campus.

At the beginning of my first semester at UVM, my brain was overloaded and stressed. I was apprehensive about what college life would be like. I didn't know what to expect and wanted to know how the program worked. Sometimes I thought, "What am I getting myself into?" In my mind I began to think, "This is going to be too hard. I should just give up."

I felt like I was drowning in fear and anxiety. What if I didn't succeed? I didn't know how my classes would be or what they would entail. Learning to find my way around campus was nerve-racking. Having to develop a consistent homework schedule and doing the work on my own was difficult at times. The reading

and paper assignments were piling up like a stack of dominoes, and I was afraid everything would collapse around me. All of this was challenging to handle at first, but as I eased into the work, I felt more comfortable each day and felt less insecure and less anxious.

One of the things that I had to learn how to do was communicate with my professor when I needed more time on a project or reading assignment. When I needed help in these areas, I learned how to communicate with my program manager, mentors, and academic advisor as well. I began to understand how to develop a course of study at UVM that best suited my particular needs and goals for the future. I realized that if I wanted to “make the grade,” I had to put in the time and work hard. Throughout my time at UVM, I learned how to be a better self-advocate and ask for accommodations when I needed them. This was an important aspect of becoming an independent college student.

At UVM, I interacted with my mentors on a daily basis. They helped me with my homework and helped me to improve my time management skills. They taught me how to use the public transportation system to get home and around campus. At first, I was nervous because I didn’t know the mentors and I didn’t know how well we would get along or how they would perceive me. However, as time went on I learned to treat them like peers and they did the same with me. When I started trusting them, we began to learn from each other. I looked up to my mentors, and they gave me guidance and support.

My classmates were also kind and respectful. They helped me learn and grow. I learned how to communicate better with my classmates and my professors. I also learned how to improve my interactions with people without disabilities. I invited one classmate to lunch, and we ate together and have since become friends. I got the courage to build relationships with other students who are different from me.

Because of the help I received from my mentors and my own hard work, I have become a better self-advocate. I took a course through Green Mountain Self-Advocates called “GMSA’s 7 Habits of Highly Effective People.” It was helpful because it included group activities where

we learned teamwork skills, building confidence, communicating with each other, and participating together as a group. This course helped me learn how to cooperate within a group and how to interact with other students.

I completed my program and received my nine-credit UVM Continuing Education

Certificate of Professional Studies. I now have the confidence to succeed in the outside world. At the beginning of the program, I didn’t know much about who I was or where I wanted to go—I just wanted to go to college. Now, I have a purpose; I know what I want to achieve in life.

Someday, I hope to become a professional self-advocate. I want to help people learn that even if they have had tough lives, they can still go to college and grow and learn. I put my mind to it, and I was able to have a new beginning and new chapter to my story. I know that the skills that I have learned and will learn at UVM will help me to reach this goal.

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